

China’s Retirement Age Policy: A Gendered Design

China’s modern retirement policy framework was largely established in the late 1970s. According to the Provisional Regulations of the State Council on the Retirement and Resignation of Workers (GF No. 104 [1978]):

Men	60
Female cadres	55
Female workers	50

Structural implication:
Career horizons are policy-defined and gender-differentiated.

These rules apply broadly across enterprise employment and remain a defining feature of China’s labor system. Unlike eligibility-based systems, these age limits function as hard exit points, irrespective of individual health status, performance, or organizational demand.

From a structural perspective, this creates gender-differentiated career horizons embedded directly in policy.